

marriage to Leila was shortlived although they had an amiable relationship. But it was Jaitly who has dominated Fernandes's mindspace. "George's tragedy is more poignant because the party was almost like family to him. And even they ditched him," says former Samata Party colleague Digvijay Singh referring to the JD(U)'s denial of a Lok Sabha ticket to Fernandes. He fought as an independent and lost his deposit in the 2009 polls. "I broke my silence after 25 years when I realised that George was being abused. How could a person who cannot walk or talk be made to fight elections? If she (Jaya) cared

a Rajya Sabha seat for herself. Her calculation was that Fernandes would cut into the votes of official party candidate, and that JD(U) would ask him to withdraw, leaving her free to bargain for a Rajya Sabha seat.

The first flashpoint between the two women was on December 18, 2009, when Sean and Leila visited Fernandes and obtained a thumb impression from him. A worried D'Sa called the staff at the house and asked them to check if there were any inkmarks on Fernandes's thumb. The servants confirmed there was. Soon

where most of the guests were Leila's friends with Sharad Yadav being the only political invitee. According to Richard, "It was a stunt to legitimise their medieval midnight coup." Michael says that Leila had told the brothers that she did not want anything for herself or Sean. "Even when Paul met her in late 2009, she had seconded it and now it seems so different," he says. Sean, on the other hand, says that he felt sorry for his father who spent most of the day in the study and was being looked after by a domestic help with Jaitly dropping in only twice a day. Soon they shifted Fernandes to a hospital in south Delhi and then to Baba Ramdev's ashram. Richard says, "It is suspicious that someone comes back after 25 years when there is money involved." An indignant Sean denies the allegation, saying, "It's equally suspicious to say that we were missing for 25 years. My father is a busy man but we met as often as his schedule permitted. We revoked the power of attorney to ensure that his assets be used for his care first and then for charity."

If it is all about inheritance, the plot is nothing new, with enough international examples. In Italy, Margherita Agnelli de Pahlen asked for a full accounting of her father, Fiat Chairman Gianni Agnelli's estimated \$2-billion inheritance, alleging there was a fortune hidden abroad. Or take the unseemly battle that Jackie Kennedy waged when her former husband Aristotle Onassis died to relinquish her claim on what his daughter Christina would inherit. They eventually settled. The 85-year-old son of New York's legendary socialite Brooke Astor was found guilty of trying to defraud his mother, who suffered from Alzheimer's, to appropriate for himself her \$185-million fortune.

For the first time in his life, Fernandes is a passive character in a script that is part tragedy and part farce. "Sometimes he picks up the paper and reads it upside down," says Leila. If he could read the papers now, it would break his heart.

with Stephen David in Bangalore



FERNANDES WITH SON SEAN, DAUGHTER-IN-LAW CHIKAKO AND GRANDSON KEN

for him how could she push him?" asks Leila. She had also accompanied Fernandes when he took oath as a Rajya Sabha member. Leila says she stepped in when she realised people were trying to take advantage of his poor health. "He was living in a dingy room with no personal care. I decided that he should get a professional attendant to take care of him. George agreed but then I received an email from Fredrick D'Sa, saying that Jaitly was not in favour," says Leila. Quoting Jaitly, D'Sa wrote, "Jaya rejected the proposal saying, 'George is fit enough to take care of himself. Also, appointing an attendant-cum-helper will send the wrong message in political circles which may affect his present political position.'" The anti-Jaitly camp also claims that she was eyeing

after Jaitly got a letter revoking her power of attorney, she asked the brothers to intervene, saying that Fernandes's condition was rapidly deteriorating. Ironically, on January 2, as Richard and Aloysius flew to Delhi, the other faction too was getting armed. Leila summoned Sean to India and that night both moved into Fernandes's house. The next day, Richard followed suit. Sean also filed a complaint at the Tughlaq Road police station, stating that outsiders (Jaitly) should not be allowed to enter as he apprehended danger. Incidentally, Sean was stepping into his father's house after 20 years. When he was 15, he had stormed out of the house after a fight with Jaitly.

The next day, mother and son organised a tea party for Fernandes